

information. These cards were much simpler to make compared to the ones that had microprocessors which ultimately raised production levels and lowered the cost for consumers.

S3 was the first company to launch a 2D accelerator, in 1991, with the launch of their single-chip 2D accelerator, the 86C911. Once 2D graphics hit the desktop, the rest of the revolution was user-driven. Software developers began experimenting with graphics, and slowly but surely, the PC gaming idea began taking form. The early 2D games included the ever-popular *Wolf* and the *Prince of Persia*.

3Dfx

3Dfx was the first company to introduce the 3D video accelerator to the desktop PC. This was the Voodoo 1, and was not available to the general public. 3Dfx sold these accelerators to OEMs who put in their labels and manufactured and marketed the cards. 3Dfx did this since it thought the cost of the cards at which they would retail in the market would be too high, and that the OEM route was more lucrative.

The Voodoo 1 was more of an add-on card that needed to be daisy-chained with the VGA card for display. This card would start working when the user started playing 3D games on the computer. And for the graphics at those times, this card made users drool when playing games.

3Dfx deserves a notable mention here since it was the first company to come out with a 3D accelerator card. It was the catalyst the fledgling gaming industry needed to draw users to play games on the computer. And, 3Dfx was more than successful in doing that.

3Dfx was followed by several other manufacturers such as PowerVR and Rendition, but no one could gain as much popularity as the Voodoo. ATi was already on the scene, but still lagged behind 3Dfx. And after nVidia hit the graphics card industry, everything changed: the rest, as they say, is history.